DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Is Man's Service in This World?

Daat Tevunot §96

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** Revision of Sections 1-4, then §96 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 23 February 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Revision: the four sections so far

Before opening Section 5, the Rabbi went back over the first four sections of the book, using the English summaries at the end of each section. He asked everyone to read those pages again over Shabbat: "It's not hard. It's 10-15 pages. To understand the next bit, we're going to need it."

Section 1 (summary on page 20): why God created the world. This is what we learned in Derech Hashem. God is good, and the good wants to bestow goodness. But we must earn that goodness. Perfection is closeness to God and imperfection is distance from Him, so the world was created imperfect, so that we can earn our good.

Section 2 (page 82): the oneness of God, Yihud Hashem. God's oneness means there is no other force. Nothing in the universe can go against His will. The Ramhal brought five mistaken views about God, and all of them fall away before Yihud Hashem, which is the central element of creation. To reveal it, evil must exist, because evil creates the facade of other powers. When that facade is exposed as part of God's plan, His oneness is revealed. The Rabbi called this "the why and the how": evil exists so that we have choice (the why), and it works through the revelation of Yihud Hashem (the how). Evil will be abolished in one of two ways: either we do it, every time we refuse sin and recognise evil as a facade, or it will come about by itself.

Section 3 (page 136): the time of concealment. When we speak of God, we never speak of God Himself, only of His attributes in the world. There are two modes: hanhagat hamishpat, the rule of justice and consequences, and the mode of yihud, in which God overrides the rules. His example was a home with a sheet of rules and consequences for the children; that is mishpat. Yihud is the parent saying, I made these rules and I normally keep them, but I am overriding them. The world runs openly by mishpat, but in the background yihud is always at work, bringing the world to its perfection. The irony is that what we see is the concealment, while the revelation working behind it is hidden.

Section 4 (page 224): body and soul. The relationship between body and soul in each epoch reflects how much concealment and how much light there is. The body has many parts, like concealment; the soul is one organic unit, like God's oneness. Until 6,000 the body is in control and the soul must battle it. From 6,000 to 7,000 the soul rules but the body's nature is

unchanged; it is a guest. From 7,000 to 8,000 the body is submissive but keeps precise recollections; from 8,000 to 9,000 vague ones; and from 9,000 to 10,000 the body is wholly drawn into the soul.

A word on Adar

Since Adar had begun, the Rabbi tied the month to everything above. "When Adar begins, we increase our happiness." Why Adar and not Nisan or Tishrei? And why does the Gemara say that someone with a court case should try to schedule it for Adar, when the Gemara also says "ein mazal leYisrael", there is no mazal for Israel?

His answer: if a person lives within the world of mazal and the constellations, then Adar is good for him and Av is bad. But if he lives directly with Hashem, with Yihud Hashem, the months make no difference, because he goes straight to the source.

Adar is the month of the revelation of Yihud Hashem because the story of Esther is exactly what we have been learning. Throughout the Megillah the concealment is visible: where is Hashem? He is not even mentioned. Only at the end do you see that the whole story was being orchestrated. Pesah is different. There the hand of God was open: the plagues, the splitting of the sea, the magicians admitting "this is the finger of God." Purim is the only festival that takes place in exile, because it is the festival of galut, of hester, where it does not look as if Hashem is involved, yet behind the scenes everything is arranged. Living with that recognition is the great happiness of "marbim besimhah", though the Rabbi admitted it is easier said than done.

§96: the general service of man

Section 5 opens on page 232 with the Sekhel turning to man in this world, "the time of service". We said at the end of Section 4 that only the 6,000 years can really be understood, so now we look at that period in detail.

What is the service in general? The Ramhal answers: to remove the evil, the imperfection in creation that will one day be abolished. Man's work is first to remove it from himself, and afterwards from the whole of creation. As Hazal say, "the world was created for me": each of us is responsible for rectifying the world. The Rabbi added the Gemara's teaching that you first remove the splinter from between your own teeth before removing someone else's.

The Ramhal brings a Midrash on "ki khashalta baavonekha", for you have stumbled in your sin. It is like a large rock standing at a crossroads, and people keep falling over it. The king says: chip away at it bit by bit, and in the end I will take the whole rock away. That is our service: we chip at the evil as much as we can, and God will finish removing it.

A question: how far does my responsibility go?

A participant asked whether evil that crosses my path, something I come across in the street or in life, is also my responsibility, or whether I can leave it to someone else. The Rabbi agreed that when it is directly in front of you, there is a duty. You start with yourself, then what is directly around you, then wider circles. He compared it to the Halacha of lending money: your

family comes first, then your relatives, then your city, then other cities. When we clearly see something we can help with, we are obliged; the details depend on each circumstance.

Evil is something new

The Ramhal then says that to explain the details of our service, we must first explain how evil came about, since the purpose of all service is to remove it. And he stresses that evil is a complete novelty. Before God brought it about there was no trace of evil at all, because God is perfect.

The good in our world is not God's real good. It has been filtered and diluted through all the chains of creation, yet it can still be traced back to Him. Evil cannot. It is the opposite of God, something He Himself does not have. In creating it, God shows that He has no limits: "yoser or uvore hoshekh, oseh shalom uvore ra", I form light and create darkness, make peace and create evil. Yet we must never forget the Midrash of the rock: the God who created evil will remove it, because its whole purpose is to create reward for the righteous.

The next classes will develop where evil comes from and how that relates to our service.

Summary

- The first four sections taught: the purpose of creation is to bestow good that we earn; Yihud Hashem is the centre of creation; during concealment yihud works hidden behind mishpat; and body and soul mirror concealment and revelation through the epochs.
- Adar is the month of hidden revelation: in the Megillah God is concealed throughout, yet everything is orchestrated.
- §96: man's service is to remove evil, first from himself and then from the world, like chipping at the rock until the King removes it.
- Our responsibility starts with ourselves and widens to what is in front of us.
- Evil is a total novelty with no trace in God, which is why the Ramhal must now explain how it comes about.

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